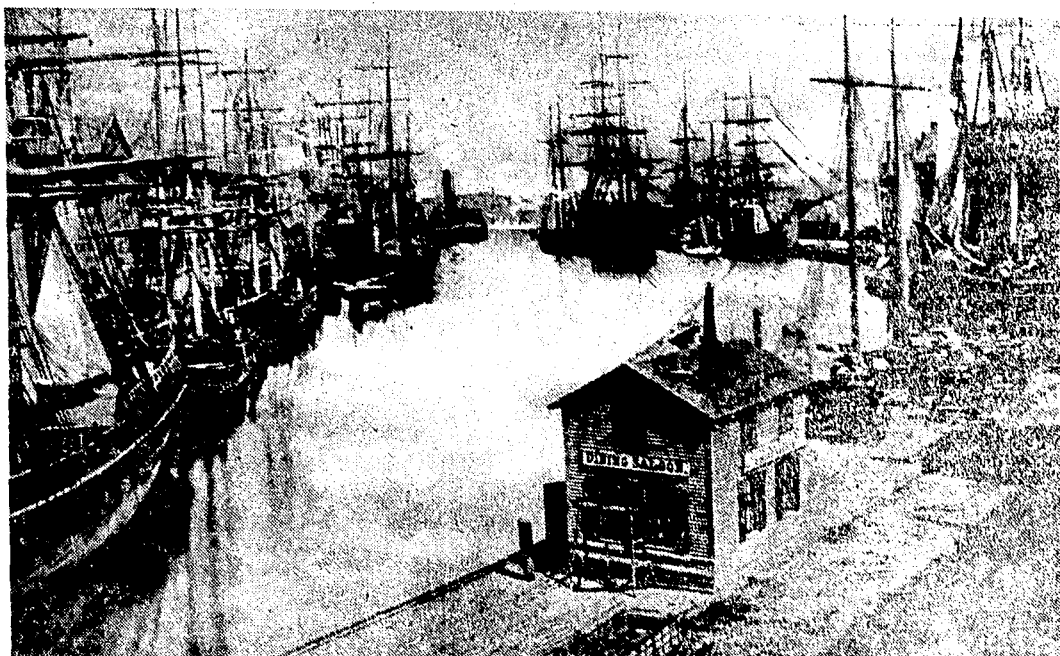




The Boston waterfront as it really was in 1857, unclouded by nostalgic whimsy.

Why tear down today's Boston to build mirage of yesterday?

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

Why is it that whenever anyone thinks about doing any redevelopment in Boston, he always begins with the assumption that the first thing to do is carve out a big hunk of the existing city and throw it away?

They threw out the West End to make Charles River Park, carved up the Fenway to create a stage for that Medicean ego trip, the Christian Science Center, and now they plan to lay waste what's left of Park Square for Park Plaza.

Of course, this makes things easy for the redeveloper — just as it was easy to redevelop Frankfurt after the bombing, or London after the fire. Fitting new buildings in with the old is a lot more trouble. Forget the fact that when new buildings and old live together, they make a far richer, yeastier mix of city life, both visually and in diversity of uses.

What brings these thoughts to mind is a proposal by, of all people, the Sierra Club. It's not that the Sierra Club wants to demolish Boston to erect the City of the Future, as Mort Zuckerman does. What it wants to do is restore the City of the Past.

But the principle is the same. It's based on deep-rooted distrust of the messy way cities really work, and a desire to substitute something much cleaner and simpler. The only difference is that one substitutes the future and the other the past.

In fact for sheer self-assurance and audacity, the Sierra Club proposal (which incidentally is backed by a lot of estimable people, including the Society of Landscape Archi-

teets, the Waterfront Restudy Committee and many others) makes Park Plaza look timid. The proposal is to demolish the Central Artery and put it underground (cost: oh, maybe half a billion plus eight years disruption while the work is being done) and restore part of the harbor shoreline to roughly what it was in 1850.

Beyond this quality of hubris, the current proposal reflects a false, stage-set conception of city life in which the city, like Disneyland, is perceived as being occupied chiefly by visitors. Instead of Disneyland's turn-of-the-century Main Street, the Sierra Club offers the Great Cove, a kind of paper-thin recreation of the Boston waterfront of 1850, focussing on a cove that is really only a fresh-water wading pool (existing utilities would still run beneath it) and an enormous public square as big as, and probably emptier than, Government Center Plaza.

A couple of handsome old warehouses stand forlornly on this square, buildings that are marvelous as part of the city's texture, but dead when isolated in such grand prominence.

Why would anyone want to recreate the past in this way? Where does it stop — should we restore the Back Bay salt marsh? Who really cares if the line of the old Eastern Packet Pier is restored or obliterated? Should cities never change?

The Great Cove proposal is part

of what seems to be a growing reaction against too much new development in the city, and as such it's to be welcomed. But surely the answer isn't a Hollywood back-lot mythical past.

In the same category with Great Cove is the over-zealous, brick-by-brick restoration of Quincy Market and North and South Market streets, now being completed nearby. Not one of these places is ever going to look as it once did, even if that were desirable — not with skyscrapers towering next door. Such an approach is a sign of deep lack of faith in the city and in ourselves.

I hope that architect Benjamin Thompson, when he takes over the perfectly restored shells in Quincy Market, bashes out a few walls just to show there's still some zest and talent in the city.

I hope someone else fills up Great Cove and its vast empty park with good, well designed, sympathetic housing and shopping and lets the tourists walk along the real waterfront, not a Cecil B. DeMille recreation.

In different senses, both the Park Plazas and the Great Coves are big and rather simple-minded Utopias. There's probably more real vitality in Coolidge Corner than in both of them put together.

Maybe, instead of wiping the slate clean each time around, we should think about building slowly and carefully on what we have.